

TOPIC 2: CRAFTS

1. Meaning of Crafts

Crafts are objects made by hand using skill and traditional techniques. They are practical or decorative items produced mainly by hand rather than by machines. Craft work involves the skilful use of materials such as wood, clay, metal, leather, fibres, beads and paper to create useful or beautiful objects.

A craftsperson (or artisan) is a person who makes crafts. Crafts are an important part of Cultural and Creative Arts because they combine creativity with practical skill.

2. Types of Crafts

Common types of crafts found in Nigeria and taught in schools include:

- **Pottery / Ceramics** – making pots, bowls, plates and decorative items from clay.
- **Weaving** – making cloth, mats, baskets and bags from threads, raffia or grass.
- **Basketry** – weaving baskets and containers from cane, raffia or palm leaves.
- **Wood Carving / Woodwork** – carving stools, masks, doors, figures and utensils from wood.
- **Leatherwork** – making shoes, bags, belts, cushions and decorations from animal skin.
- **Beadwork** – making jewellery, crowns, belts and decorations from beads.
- **Metalwork / Blacksmithing** – making tools, knives, ornaments and sculptures from metal.
- **Tie and Dye / Batik** – decorating fabrics with patterns using dyes.
- **Paper Craft** – making useful and decorative items from paper.
- **Calabash Carving / Decoration** – decorating gourds for storage or display.
- **Embroidery and Needlework** – decorating cloth with needle and thread.

3. Materials Used in Crafts

Different crafts require different materials. Common materials include:

- **Clay** – for pottery and modelling.
- **Wood** – for carving, furniture and sculpture.
- **Leather / Animal skin** – for bags, shoes and decoration.
- **Fibres and Threads** – cotton, wool, raffia, jute for weaving and embroidery.
- **Beads and Cowries** – for jewellery and ornamentation.
- **Metal** – iron, brass, bronze, aluminium for tools and ornaments.
- **Paper and Cardboard** – for paper crafts.
- **Dyes and Pigments** – natural or synthetic colours for fabric and other decoration.
- **Calabash / Gourds** – for containers and decorative items.
- **Cane, Bamboo and Palm Leaves** – for basketry and furniture.

4. Tools and Equipment Used in Crafts

Tools vary according to the type of craft:

- **Pottery**: potter's wheel, kiln, modelling tools, cutting wire.
- **Wood carving**: chisels, knives, adze, mallet, sandpaper.
- **Weaving**: loom, shuttle, needles, scissors.
- **Leatherwork**: awl, needles, knife, punch, hammer.
- **Beadwork**: needles, thread, beading board.

- **Metalwork:** hammer, anvil, tongs, forge, files.
- **Paper craft:** scissors, glue, ruler, pencil, cutting knife.
- **Tie and Dye:** rubber bands, string, gloves, basins, dyes.

5. Locations of Local Crafts in Nigeria

Different parts of Nigeria are famous for particular crafts:

- **Pottery:** Ilorin (Kwara), Abuja, Dada pottery (Oyo), Afikpo (Ebonyi).
- **Wood Carving:** Oyo, Ondo, Ekiti, Benin, Awka.
- **Bronze / Brass Casting:** Benin City, Ife.
- **Leatherwork:** Kano, Sokoto, Bida.
- **Weaving / Textiles:** Akwete (Abia), Okene (Kogi), Iseyin (Oyo), Kano (for indigo dyeing).
- **Beadwork:** Bida (Niger), Benin, Yoruba kingdoms.
- **Calabash Decoration:** Oyo, Hausa communities.
- **Blacksmithing:** Awka, Awgu, many northern and eastern communities.

6. Uses of Crafts in Nigeria

Crafts serve many important purposes:

- **Utilitarian / Practical Use** – pots for cooking and storage, baskets for carrying, mats for sitting, leather bags and shoes.
- **Decoration** – beautifying homes, offices and public places.
- **Cultural and Religious Use** – masks, staffs, beads and sculptures used in festivals, ceremonies and traditional worship.
- **Royal and Ceremonial Use** – crowns, beads, staffs of office for traditional rulers.
- **Economic Use** – crafts are sold locally and exported, providing income and employment.
- **Tourism** – tourists buy crafts as souvenirs, promoting Nigerian culture abroad.
- **Educational Use** – teaching creativity, history and cultural values in schools.
- **Gift Items** – crafts are given as presents during ceremonies and festivals.

7. Summary

Crafts are handmade objects produced with skill and creativity. Nigeria has a rich variety of crafts including pottery, weaving, carving, leatherwork and beadwork. Each craft uses specific materials and tools, and different regions specialise in particular crafts. Crafts are useful for daily life, decoration, culture, economy and education.

End of Topic 2 – Crafts